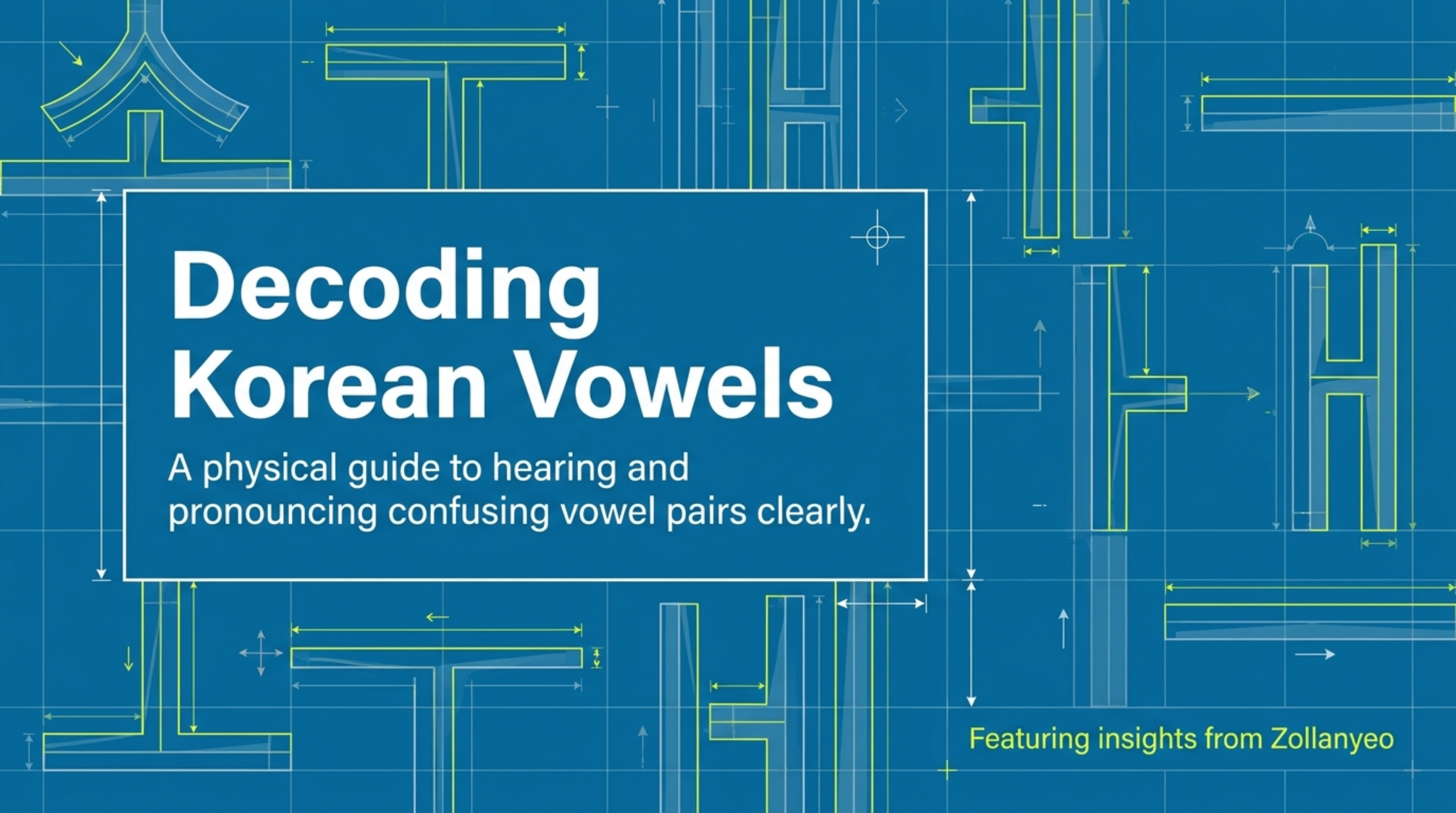




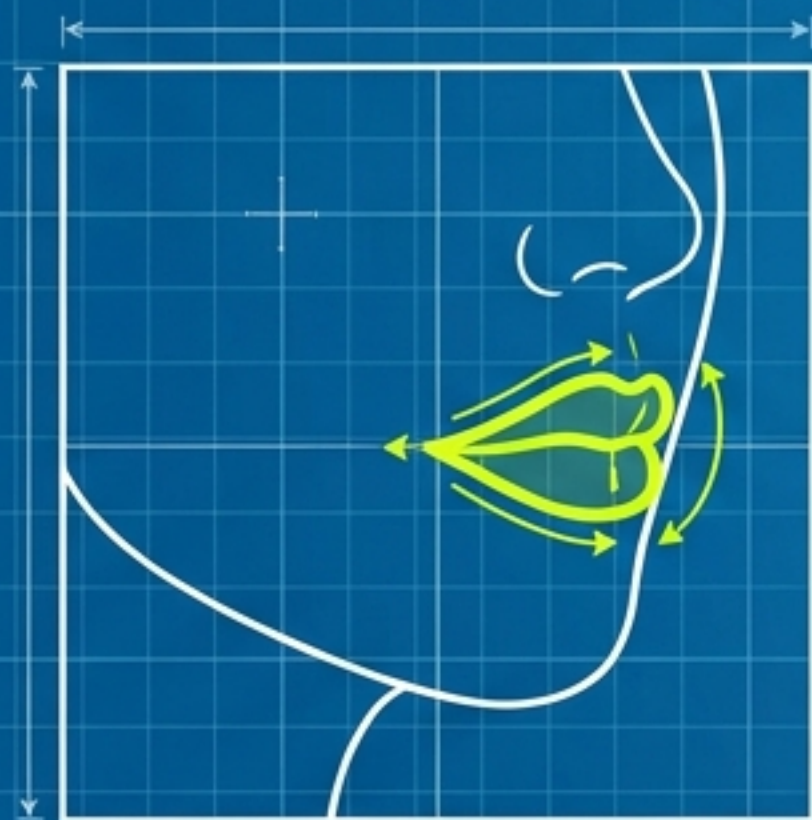
Decoding Korean Vowels

A physical guide to hearing and
pronouncing confusing vowel pairs clearly.

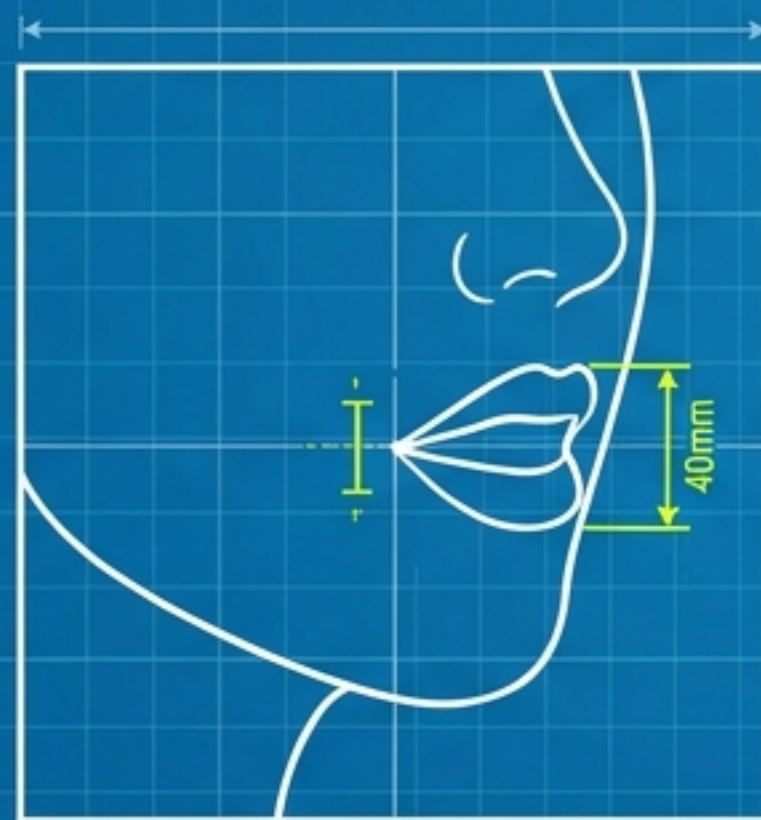
Featuring insights from Zollanyeo

The secret to Korean listening is physical articulation.

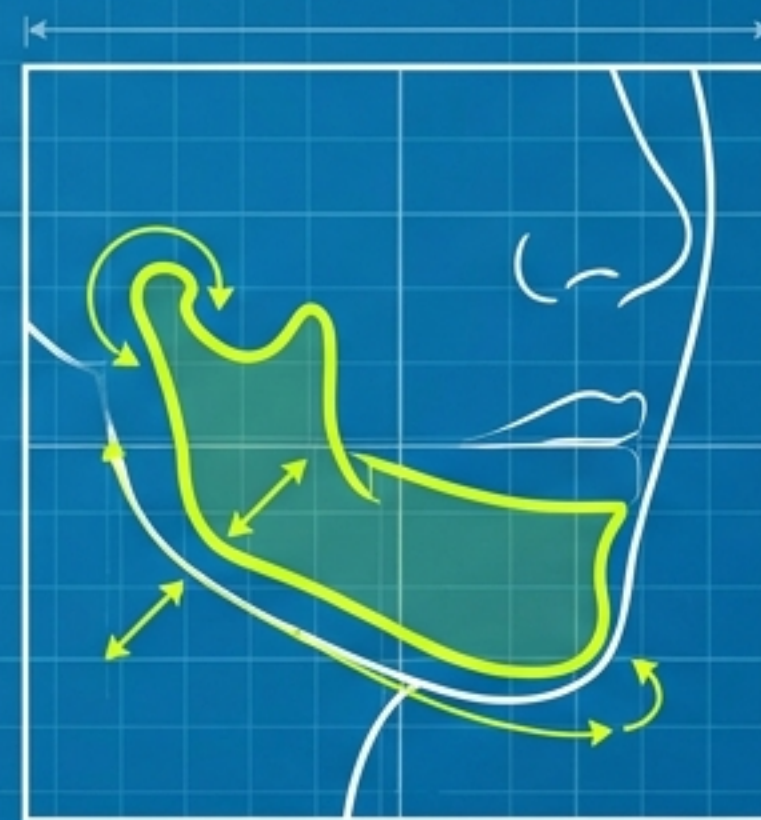
To hear the subtle differences in Korean vowels, you must understand how they are built.
Master these four physical levers to unlock clear auditory comprehension.



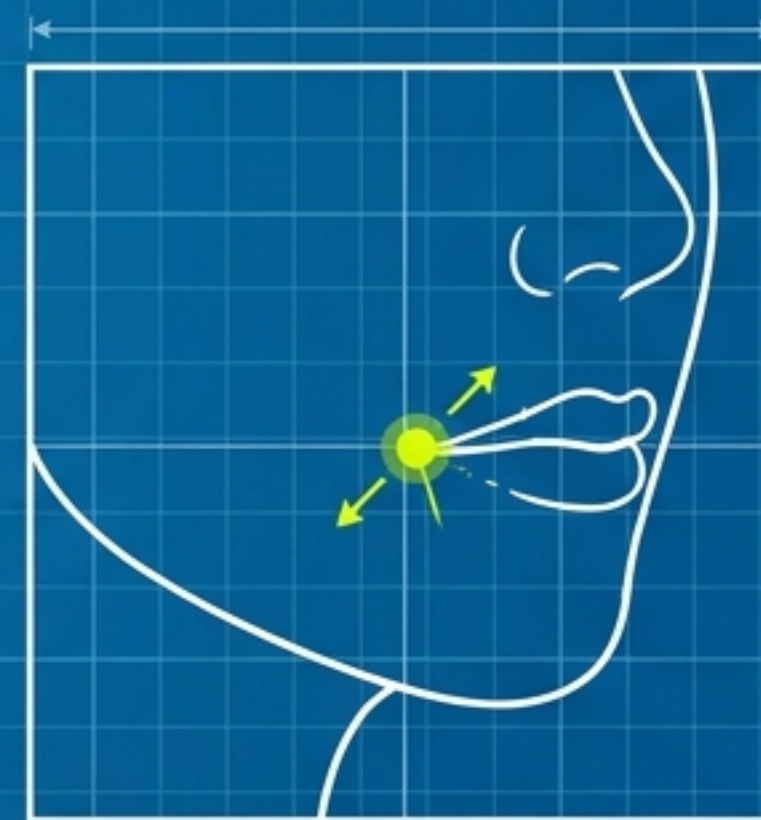
Lip Shape



Mouth Size

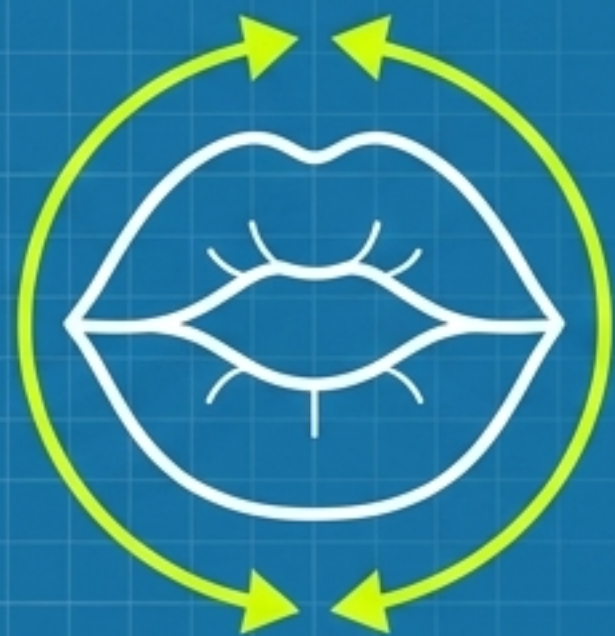
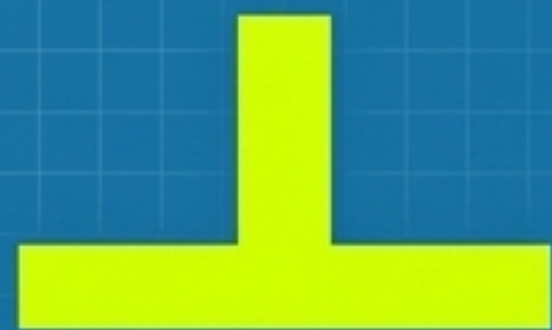


Jaw Position



Lip Tension

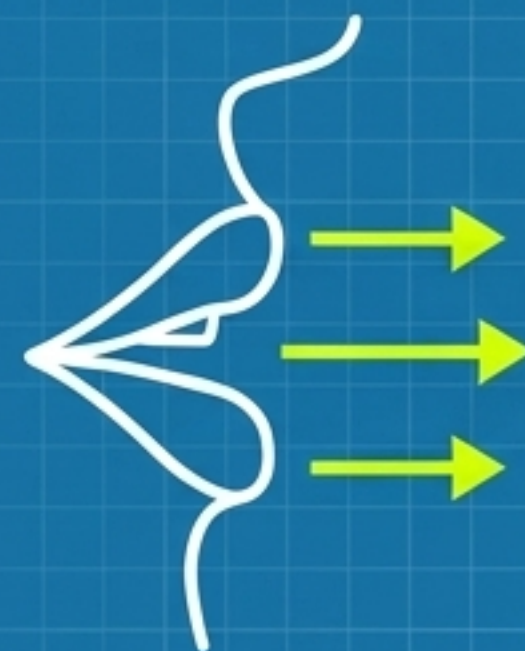
Lip shape differentiates ㅏ (o) and ㅜ (u).



Lip
Roundness

Round your lips strictly
to make an 'o' sound.

Practice: 오리 (Duck)



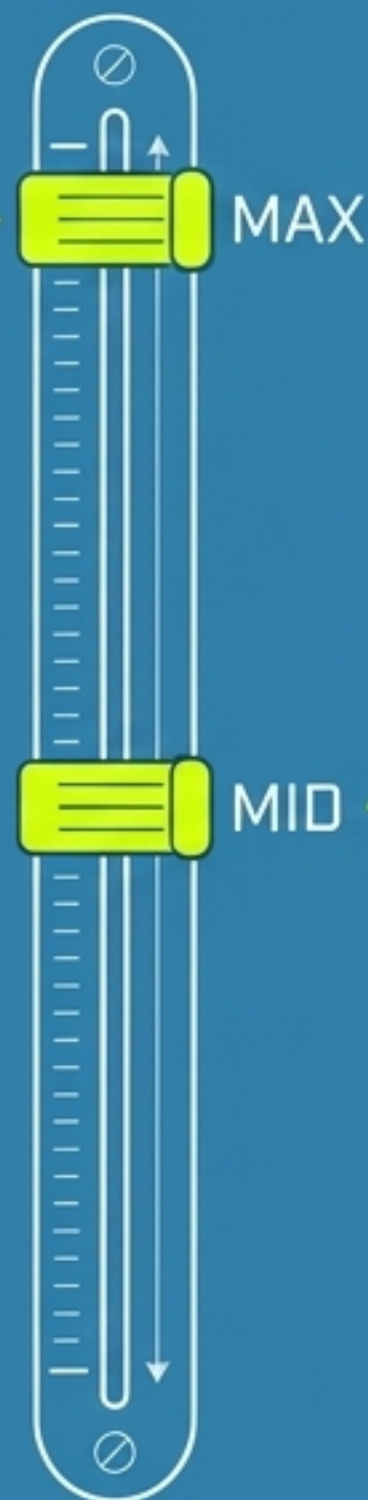
Lip
Extension

Push your lips out further
to make a 'u' sound.

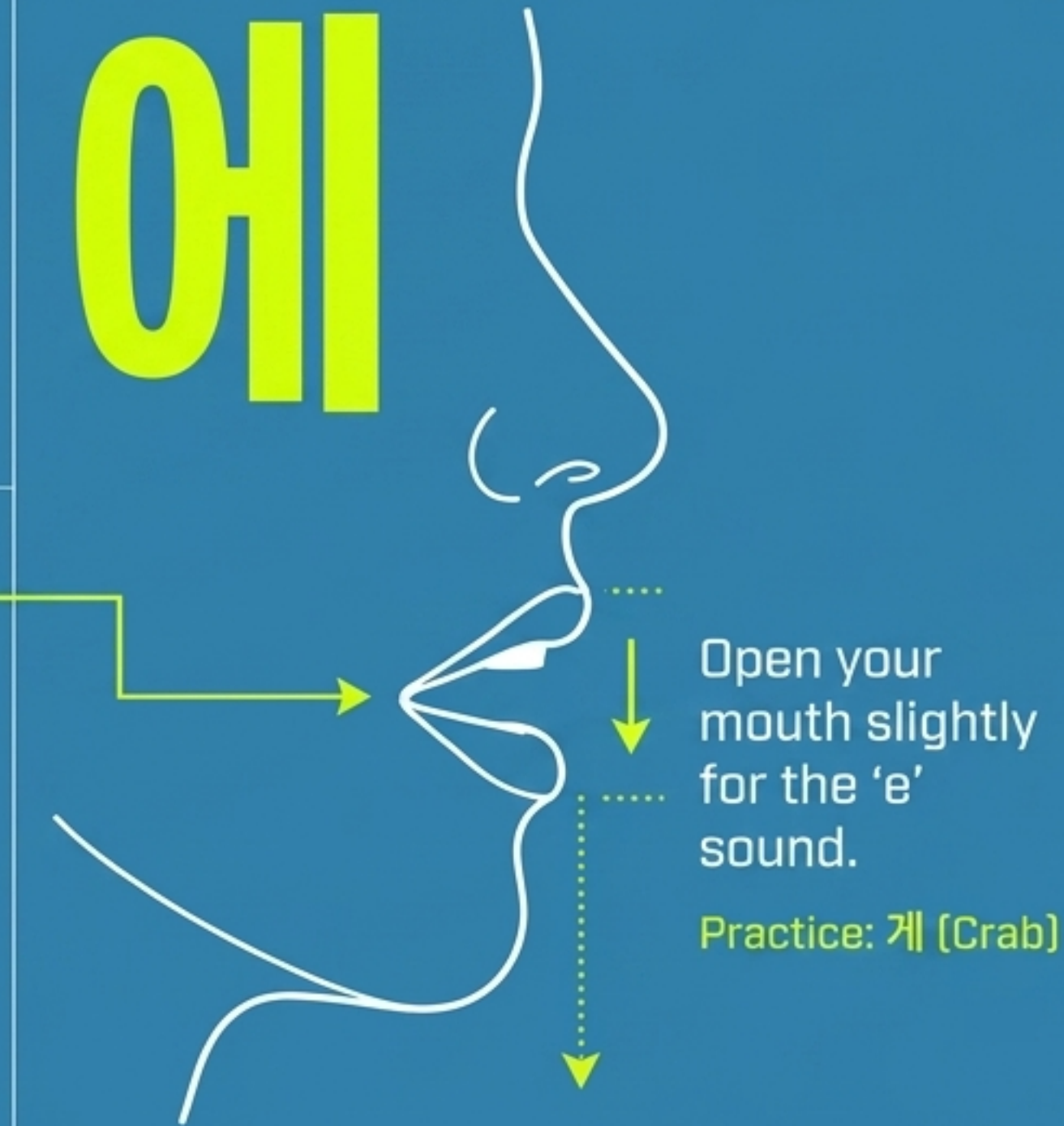
Practice: 우유 (Milk)

Mouth size controls the difference between **ㅏ** [ae] and **ㅓ** [e].

ㅏ

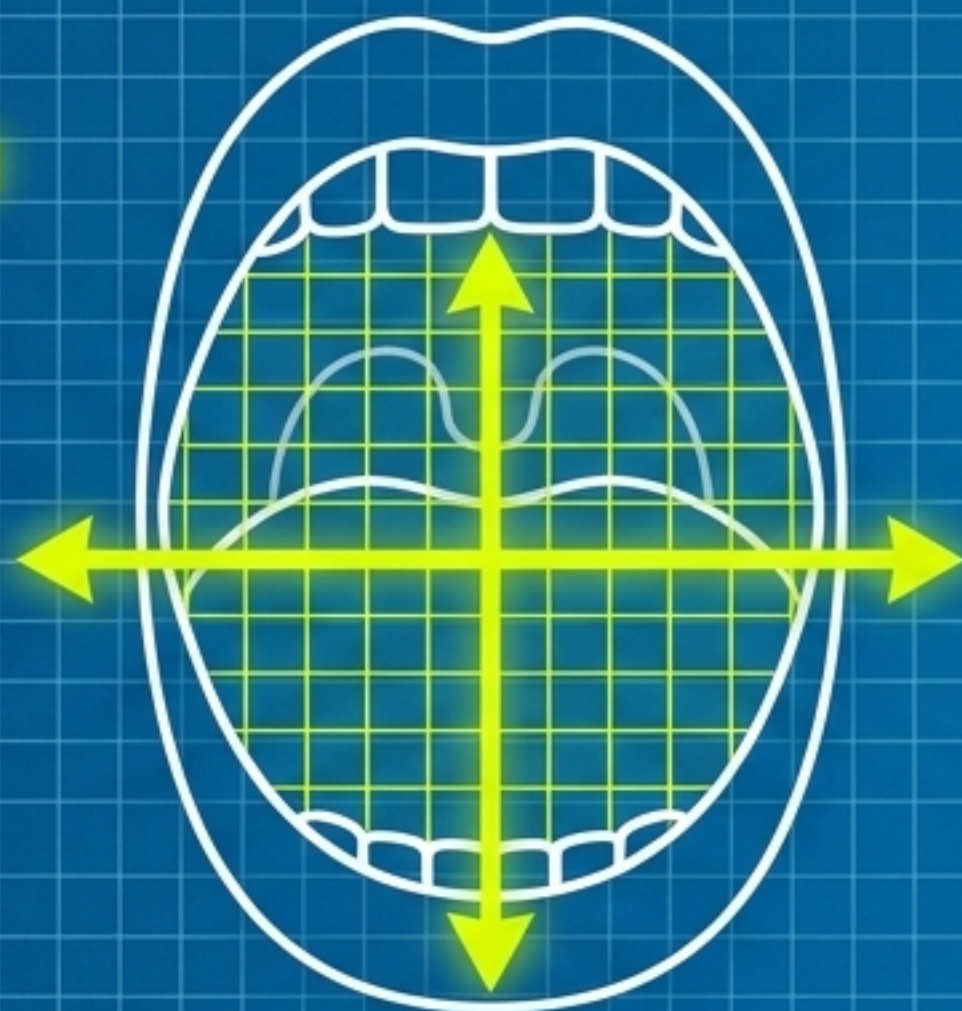


ㅓ



Jaw position separates ㅏ (a) from ㅑ (eo).

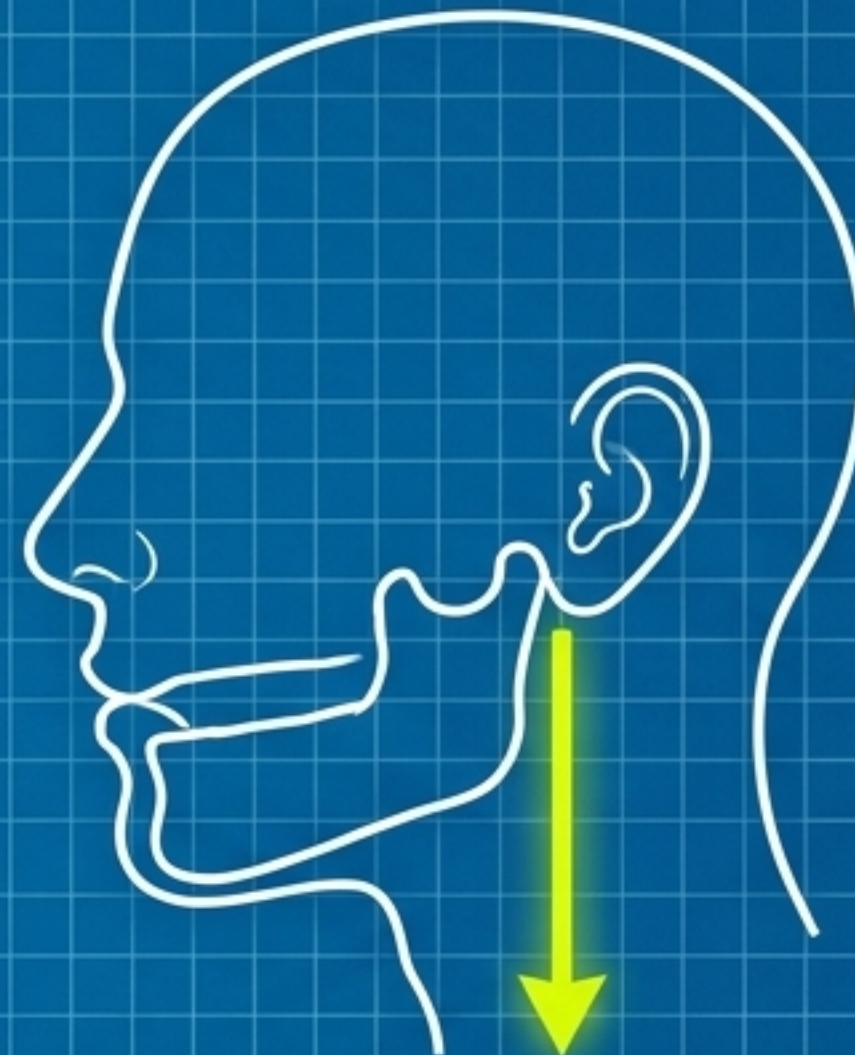
ㅏ



Open your mouth wide
for the 'a' sound.

Practice: 말 (Horse)

ㅑ



Open your mouth slightly and
lower your jaw for the 'eo' sound.

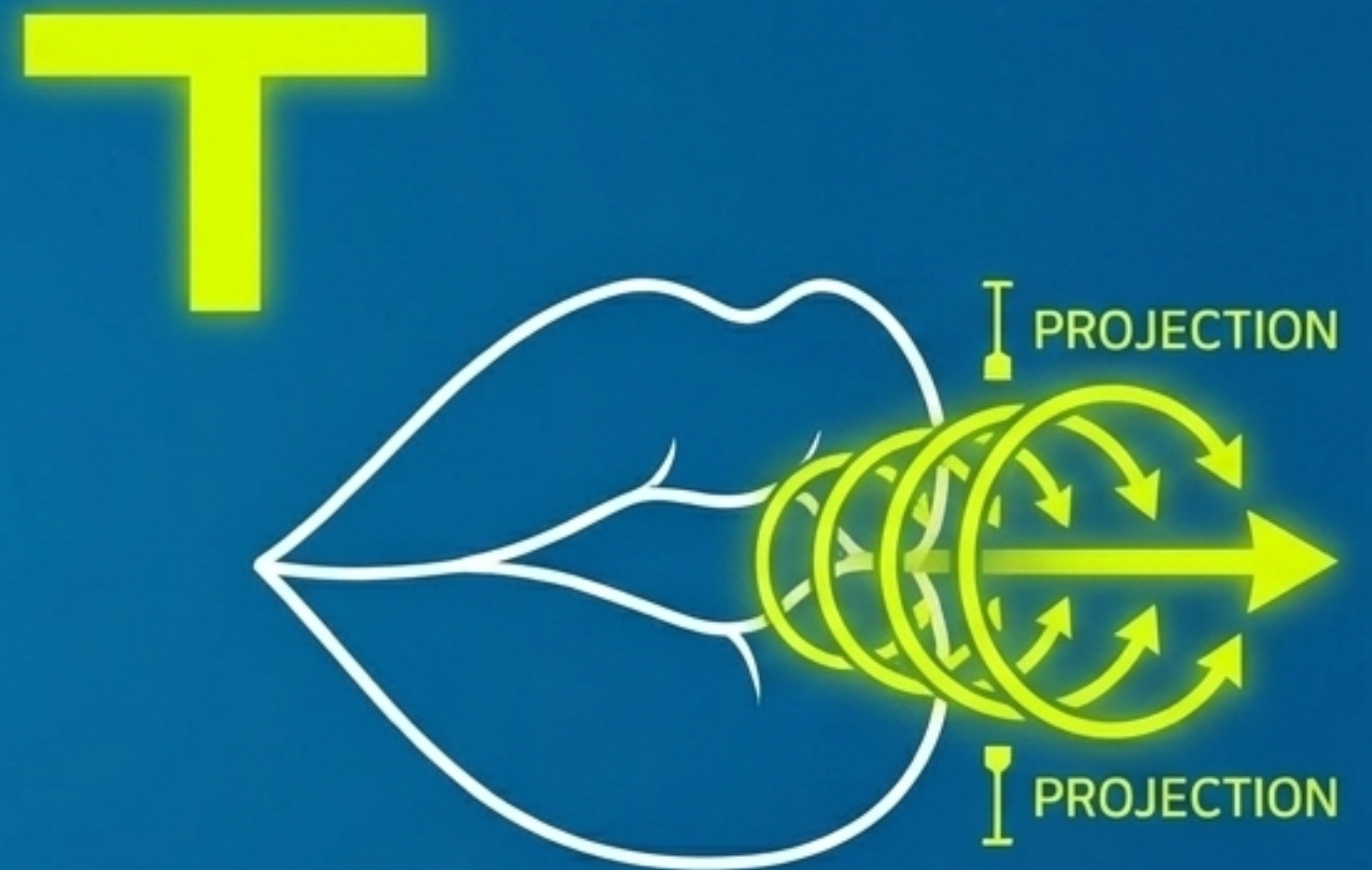
Practice: 머리 (Head)

Lip tension defines — (eu) versus τ (u).



Pull your lips slightly to the sides to create the 'eu' sound.

Practice: 불 (Fire)



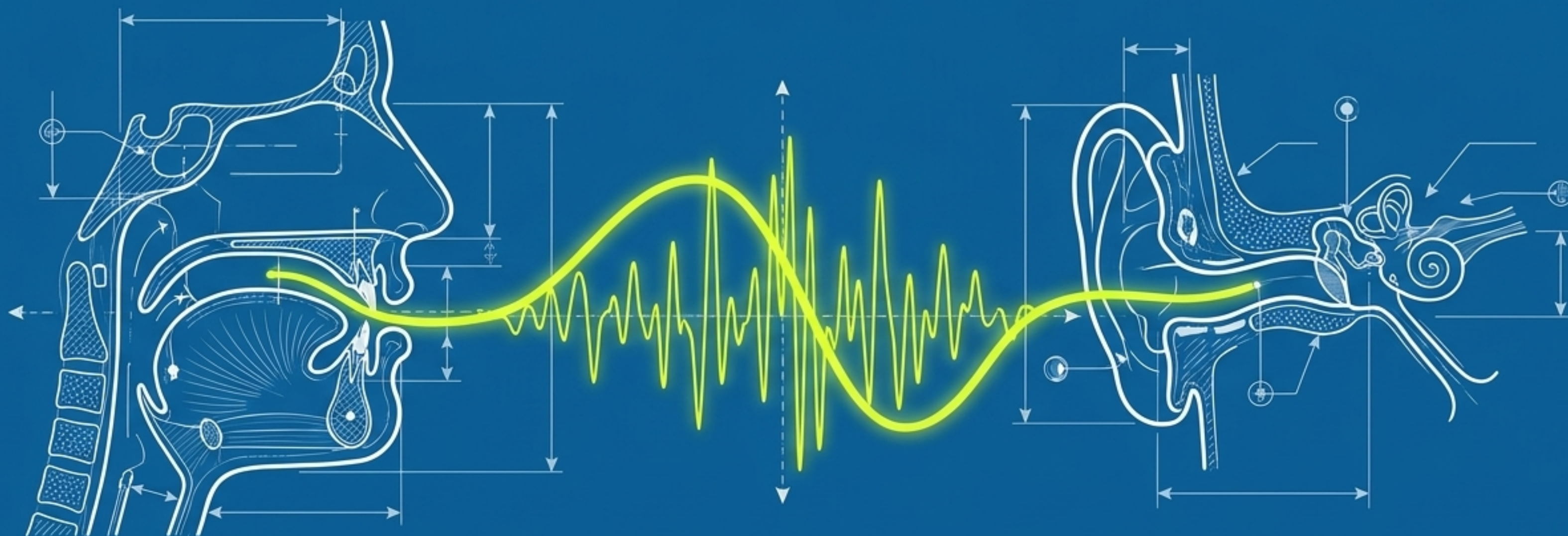
Round and push your lips out to create the 'u' sound.

Practice: 뿔 (Horn)

The Complete Vowel Articulation Matrix

<u>Vowel Pair</u>	<u>Primary Mechanic</u>	<u>Action A</u>	<u>Action B</u>	<u>Practice Words</u>
⌞ VS. ⌠	Lip Shape	Round lips (⌞) ↻	Push lips out (⌠) ↗ ↘	오리 / 우유
H VS. H	Mouth Size	Open wide (H)	Open slightly (H)	개 / 게
┐ VS. ┌	Jaw Position	Open wide (┐) ↑	Lower jaw (┌) ↓	말 / 머리
— VS. ⌠	Lip Tension	Pull to sides (—) ← →	Round & push (⌠) ↻	불 / 뿔

Train the mouth to train the ear.



Getting used to subtle vowel differences requires understanding how they are physically produced. Your ear learns to recognize these specific physical shapes in spoken audio over time.

Listen repeatedly. Practice consistently. By focusing on physical articulation, your Korean listening skills will improve significantly.